India's Counterforce Temptations

Strategic Dilemmas, Doctrine, and Capabilities

Christopher Clary and Vipin Narang

Is India shifting to a nuclear counterforce strategy? The conventional wisdom is that India only reluctantly acquired nuclear weapons and has been a restrained nuclear weapons power that adheres to a no-first-use (NFU) policy and rejects the possibility of nuclear warfighting. Although the empirical record largely bears out its reluctance to acquire nuclear weapons,[1] India's continued nuclear restraint is less certain. Specifically, India is developing a suite of capabilities and increasingly making statements about preemption and counterforce that appear inconsistent with its professed strategy of assured retaliation or minimum deterrence.

This article identifies, and attempts to explain, why India has devoted considerable resources since 2003 to develop and acquire capabilities that exceed what is required for a strictly retaliatory nuclear arsenal. Specifically, why has India sought to build a diverse and growing number of accurate and responsive nuclear delivery systems at higher states of readiness, an increasing array of surveillance platforms, and both indigenous and imported air and ballistic missile defenses? Moreover, these capability developments have emerged alongside an increasing number of public statements by serving and retired Indian national security officials arguing that preemptive counterforce options against Pakistan are permissible doctrinally and advantageous strategically.[2]

Christopher Clary is an assistant professor of political science at the University at Albany, State University of New York. Vipin Narang is an associate professor of political science at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology and a member of MIT's Security Studies Program.

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1. See George Perkovich, *India's Nuclear Bomb: The Impact on Global Proliferation* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999); and Vipin Narang, "Strategies of Nuclear Proliferation: How States Pursue the Bomb," *International Security*, Vol. 41, No. 3 (Winter 2016/17), pp. 110–150, doi.org/10.1162/ISEC_a_00268.
2. Vipin Narang, "Plenary: Beyond the Nuclear Threshold: Causes and Consequences of First Use," remarks prepared for the Carnegie International Nuclear Policy Conference, Washington, D.C., March 20, 2017, https://fbfy83yid9j1dqsev3zq0w8n-wpengine.netdna-ssl.com/wp-content/uploads/2013/08/Vipin-Narang-Remarks-Carnegie-Nukefest-2017.pdf.

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We argue that these apparently discrepant capability developments are most likely the result of India's conscious pursuit of more flexible options beyond countervalue targeting—namely, counterforce options against Pakistan's longer-range nuclear systems—and are largely not the product of either technological drift or strategic confusion.

If our assessment is correct, then these developments are an early indication of India's exploration and development of options to target Pakistan's strategic nuclear systems in a conflict. Unlike India's nuclear strategy toward China, which appears to remain countervalue assured retaliation, available evidence suggests that India may be developing options toward Pakistan that would permit it to engage in hard nuclear counterforce targeting, providing India a limited ability to disarm Pakistan of strategic nuclear weapons.[3] Such a development would entail a decoupling of India's nuclear strategies toward its two neighbors.

A shift to incorporating nuclear counterforce options may be an attempt to escape India's strategic paralysis following Pakistan's development of tactical nuclear weapons, which Pakistan threatens to use against Indian conventional forces should they cross certain red lines. What can India do if Pakistan uses one or several tactical nuclear weapons against Indian forces? India's official nuclear doctrine explicitly threatens massive retaliation against any such use, which outside observers have widely interpreted as implying a major countervalue strike against Pakistani cities. Nevertheless, many have questioned the credibility of massive retaliation—whether any Indian leader would in fact order the killing of millions of innocent Pakistani civilians in response to nuclear use on Indian forces operating on Pakistani soil.[4] If India chose not to retaliate with massive force, it could attempt a proportional tit-for-tat response. Such a response, however, would cede the nuclear initiative back to Pakistan, which,

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3. Hard counterforce implies attacks against hardened targets, such as nuclear weapons storage facilities or leadership bunkers, which are difficult to destroy. Soft counterforce implies attacks against area targets, such as military bases, where even one fission warhead would likely cause meaningful destruction. Given the difficulty of destroying mobile targets, such as missile transporters, we consider such attacks as part of "hard counterforce."

4. See P.R. Chari, "India's Nuclear Doctrine: Stirrings of Change" (Washington, D.C.: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, June 4, 2014), https://carnegieendowment.org/2014/06/04/india-s-nuclear-doctrine-stirrings-of-change-pub-55789; Raja Menon, "A Mismatch of Nuclear Doctrines," *Hindu*, January 22, 2014; Rajesh Rajagopalan, "India's Nuclear Doctrine Debate" (Washington, D.C.: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, June 30, 2016), https://carnegieendowment.org/2016/06/30/india-s-nuclear-doctrine-debate-pub-63950; Zorawar Daulet Singh, "Is India's Nuclear Doctrine Credible?" *Journal of Defence Studies*, Vol. 11, No. 1 (January–March 2017), pp. 111–118, https://idsa.in/jds/jds_11_1_2017_is-india-nuclear-doctrine-credible; and George Perkovich and Toby Dalton, *Not War, Not Peace? Motivating Pakistan to Prevent Cross-Border Terrorism* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2016), pp. 190–193.

retaining its long-range strategic nuclear weapons, could respond by destroying one or several Indian cities. Further, pursuing such graduated options would place enormous pressure on India's command and control system.[5]

Thus, some Indian policymakers appear to be attracted to a third option: a hard counterforce strike against Pakistan's relatively small number—perhaps several dozen—strategic nuclear assets on land (and eventually at sea) to eliminate its ability to destroy Indian strategic targets and cities. Such a strategy would be consistent with India's doctrine of massive retaliation—massive retaliation strategies need not be countervalue—while avoiding the credibility issues associated with a countervalue targeting strategy following Pakistan's use of nuclear weapons on the battlefield. One problem with a counterforce option, however, is that, seized with the fear of a disarming strike, Pakistan would have an incentive to unleash its entire arsenal first before losing it, which in turn would encourage India to attempt a counterforce strike preemptively—a problem given India's NFU commitment, which most commentators have assumed would oblige India or its forces to suffer a nuclear detonation before retaliating. We argue that these preemptive pressures associated with counterforce targeting may explain why a number of influential Indian officials have made a persistent and otherwise puzzling argument either that India should revise its NFU policy to permit preemption or that preemptive use upon warning of imminent Pakistani launch is consistent with its existing NFU policy.

India's adoption of potentially preemptive counterforce options—even as a choice on a menu that otherwise consists of countervalue retaliation options—would mark a seismic shift in Indian nuclear strategy and the death knell of so-called credible minimum deterrence. Furthermore, if India construes preemption as consistent with its NFU policy and therefore preemptive counterforce as a form of massive retaliation, it may decide that no overt changes to its declaratory doctrine are necessary. As India's former National Security Adviser Shivshankar Menon recently stated, "India's nuclear doctrine has far greater flexibility than it gets credit for."[6] In short, India's national security officials may have already quietly concluded that preemptive counterforce options—and associated increases in strategic force capabilities—are consis-

5. Balraj Nagal, "India's Nuclear Strategy to Deter: Massive Retaliation to Cause Unacceptable Damage," *CLAWS Journal*, Winter 2015, p. 13, http://www.claws.in/images/journals_doc/440323975_balrajnagal.pdf.
6. Quoted in Ajai Shukla, "After a Pakistani TNW Strike, India Can Go for Pakistan's Nuclear Arsenal: Former NSA Shivshankar Menon," *Business Standard*, March 18, 2017, http://ajaishukla.blogspot.com/2017/03/after-pakistani-tnw-strike-india-will.html.

tent with India's existing nuclear doctrine. Therefore, there may be no explicit acknowledgment or indicators of this shift, which may force Pakistan to adjust its nuclear posture and strategy on the fear that it has already occurred.

Eliminating Pakistan's strategic nuclear weapons would be tempting for India. Rather than current military plans that aim to punish Pakistan for future provocations while avoiding Pakistan's nuclear red lines, plans for a counterforce-capable India would be able to wage whatever conventional war it prefers by eliminating the nuclear threat altogether. India might be able to reestablish deterrence against Pakistani terrorist attacks on Indian territory in ways that aborted adjustments to its conventional doctrine have failed to do.

Nevertheless, India's flirtation with nuclear counterforce carries significant risks. First, the prospects for counterforce success even against Pakistan's current force are questionable. Second, India's adoption of nuclear counterforce—or even Pakistan's fear of its adoption—could generate not just an arms race, but dangerous "first-strike instability" where neither side could afford to go second. Absent an explicit denial of Indian interest in counterforce options, Pakistan must react to the mere possibility of their existence, given that the survivability of its strategic nuclear weapons could be at stake. Consequently, Pakistan may decide that it needs to build more nuclear forces and to adopt riskier deployment patterns to enhance survivability, heightening the danger of nuclear escalation in any future military crisis.

The article proceeds as follows. First, we situate India's nuclear developments in the context of broader strategic developments in the India-Pakistan relationship. Second, we document a growing number of statements by recent Indian officials offered in a private capacity while serving or shortly after retirement that call into question India's NFU commitment and demonstrate interest in being able to execute disarming attacks. Third, we discuss Indian nuclear force developments over the last two decades, which have substantially improved India's ability to conduct hard-target counterforce strikes despite continuity in India's official nuclear doctrine. Fourth, we assess Pakistan's likely responses to these developments and conclude that India's prospects for counterforce success are dubious and the adoption of a counterforce strategy—or Pakistan's fear of its adoption—could have significant deleterious consequences. This conclusion implies that just as conventional military options have failed to resolve India's Pakistan dilemma, adjustments to its nuclear strategy are similarly unlikely to yield positive results—and may increase the risk of catastrophic outcomes. Finally, we consider the implications of these findings for scholars' understanding of theories of nuclear strategy and the prospect of a broader era of counterforce in the emerging nuclear landscape.

systems—because Pakistan would still retain longer-range strategic nuclear missiles that it could use against the Indian homeland.

The second possible approach—one that outside observers overlooked given its difficulty and perceived inconsistency with India's nuclear doctrine—centered on developing counterforce options, whereby India could launch a disarming strike against Pakistan's nuclear arsenal and then overwhelm Pakistan's remaining forces with its conventional superiority. After all, U.S. scholars had concluded that the United States' attempts to maintain "limited" nuclear options during the Cold War had provided "a strong incentive for Soviet military planners to retain preemptive [counterforce] options."[23] If India could convince Pakistan that its ability to launch a disarming strike were credible, this might nullify Pakistani nuclear threats, permitting punitive conventional attacks that could restore Indian deterrence of Pakistani subconventional attacks. At a minimum, such a capability might diminish Pakistani confidence that Pakistan could contain a nuclear exchange to the battlefield. A counterforce strategy might restore credibility to India's massive retaliation doctrine, because it would allow India to retain the nuclear initiative and would justify a massive strike to achieve disarming effect.[24]

Although the Indian military would likely try to destroy as many of Pakistan's battlefield nuclear systems as it could, the battlefield systems do not pose a threat to Indian population centers.[25] The primary concern for India would be to disarm Pakistan's longer-range strategic nuclear systems, which number in the tens, not the tens of thousands, and which India has been mapping for years. The logic is seductive: Pakistan's strategic nuclear force is currently small enough that India might believe it could be disarmed or neutralized with combined strikes on Pakistan's launchers and its command and control system, and that any remaining Pakistani nuclear weapons could be intercepted with missile defenses. Although this may sound like wishful thinking, especially after the aborted flirtation with Cold Start, India has been developing the components necessary for such a strategy. In addition, India's national security leaders have recently—and intriguingly—made statements that suggest they believe such a strategy may offer a way out of their country's current strategic paralysis.

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23. Scott D. Sagan, *Moving Targets: Nuclear Strategy and National Security* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1989), p. 64.
24. Nagal, "India's Nuclear Strategy to Deter," pp. 13–14.
25. See Feroz Hassan Khan, *South Asian Stability Workshop 2.0: A Crisis Simulation Report* (Monterey, Calif.: Naval Postgraduate School, February 2016), p. 26.

Public Statements, Private Views, and a Changing Strategy?

According to the conventional wisdom,[26] India's nuclear posture has three pillars: (1) India seeks to "[build] and [maintain] a credible minimum deterrent";[27] (2) India keeps its forces in a disassembled state to maximize safety and civilian control;[28] and (3) India has an unequivocal no-first-use policy, declaring that "nuclear weapons will only be used in retaliation against a nuclear attack on Indian territory or on Indian forces anywhere,"[29] and "consciously rule[s] out" any "preemptive use" of nuclear weapons.[30] Together, these three pillars constitute India's doctrine and strategy of assured countervalue retaliation: India would not be the first to use nuclear weapons, but it would retaliate with certainty following a nuclear attack on it (or its forces) with strategic nuclear countervalue strikes on an adversary's cities. The narrow aim of this strategy was to deter the use of weapons of mass destruction against India, not to deter Pakistani sub-conventional or conventional attacks. To achieve this objective, India would rely on a relatively small number of survivable land, air, and eventually sea-based nuclear weapons, maintained with highly centralized control at a very low level of peacetime readiness.[31]

Although some of these features—such as a declared NFU policy—may remain official doctrine, they are no longer unassailable pillars of Indian nuclear strategy. Given Pakistan's threat of first use of tactical nuclear weapons against Indian forces, India's nuclear strategy may be evolving. Recent acquisitions and readiness enhancements to its nuclear arsenal suggest a widening gap between India's capabilities and its declared nuclear deterrence goals. Additionally, in recent years, serving and retired Indian officials have begun arguing for greater flexibility in India's existing nuclear doctrine—

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26. Ashley J. Tellis, *India's Emerging Nuclear Posture: Between Recessed Deterrent and Ready Arsenal* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND Corporation, 2001); Perkovich, *India's Nuclear Bomb*; Rajesh M. Basrur, *Minimum Deterrence and India's Nuclear Security* (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 2006); and Bharat Karnad, *India's Nuclear Policy* (Westport, Conn.: Praeger Security International, 2008).
27. PMO, "Cabinet Committee on Security Reviews Progress in Operationalizing India's Nuclear Doctrine."
28. See, for example, Tellis, *India's Emerging Nuclear Posture*, p. 367.
29. PMO, "Cabinet Committee on Security Reviews Progress in Operationalizing India's Nuclear Doctrine." The policy is more accurately described as no first use of weapons of mass destruction, because India "retain[ed] the option of retaliating with nuclear weapons" to adversary use of chemical and biological weapons.
30. Jasjit Singh, "A Nuclear Strategy for India," in Singh, ed. *Nuclear India* (New Delhi: Knowledge World, 1998), p. 314.
31. Narang, *Nuclear Strategy in the Modern Era*, pp. 94–120.

or asserting that its existing doctrine is already more flexible than commonly assumed.

Such claims by serving Indian military and political officials complicate the ability of analysts to assess India's current nuclear posture and doctrine. India has produced only one official nuclear doctrine, and chose to publicly issue merely a summary of it in 2003. Since then, India's officials have made very few declaratory remarks regarding nuclear strategy or doctrine, and have pointedly avoided revising its official public doctrine. Instead, India seems to prefer pursuing any strategic shifts by creatively reinterpreting the current doctrine. Indeed, India's national security managers have repeatedly noted the flexibility of the existing doctrine. The challenge for analysts, therefore, is to infer their thinking from the few statements that they do make.

Shivshankar Menon, India's national security adviser and the point person on India's nuclear arsenal and strategy from 2011 to 2014, is the highest-level former government official to write on India's nuclear strategy since the release of the 2003 doctrine. In his book, *Choices*, Menon laid out what one can only infer might be India's operational nuclear strategy, and what he thinks it perhaps should be. His thinking is starkly different from the conventional wisdom of a minimum deterrence countervalue retaliatory strategy.[32]

First, Menon hints at possible preemptive elements in Indian nuclear strategy, which is puzzling for a state that professes an explicit NFU policy. Although he ultimately concludes that declaring no first use is in India's strategic interests, he challenges and erodes its operational absoluteness in the following scenario: "There is a potential gray area as to when India would use nuclear weapons first against another NWS [nuclear weapons state]. Circumstances are conceivable in which India might find it useful to strike first, for instance, against an NWS that had declared it would certainly use its weapons, and if India were certain that adversary's launch was imminent. But India's present public nuclear doctrine is silent on this scenario."[33] This suggestion of doctrinal silence hints at the notion that India's nuclear doctrine contains enough ambiguity to permit preemptive nuclear use if Indian leaders believed that nuclear use against it was imminent.

This was not the first time Menon cast doubt on India's commitment to an absolute NFU policy. In 2010, he gave a speech at India's National Defence

32. Shivshankar Menon, *Choices: Inside the Making of India's Foreign Policy* (Washington, D.C.: Brookings Institution Press, 2016), pp. 105–123.
33. Ibid., p. 110.

College where he used a peculiar formulation that deviated from the official doctrine to describe India's policy: "no first use against non-nuclear weapons states."[34] This formulation suggests that India's NFU policy may not apply to nuclear-armed Pakistan or China. Although some observers believed that Menon's phrasing was inadvertent,[35] the speech remains on India's official Ministry of External Affairs website without any correction. Dhruva Jaishankar, a knowledgeable Delhi-based analyst declared that this eroded formulation "wasn't a mistake,"[36] that "it was deliberate,"[37] and it was intentional "signaling . . . [to c]orrespond with other activities around that time."[38]

Menon was not working in a vacuum. There have long been skeptics within India's government and military about the advisability of a declared and absolute NFU policy—that India would accept first use, especially on its homeland.[39] Hints of preemptive elements in Indian strategy date back to at least 2000, when Prime Minister Vajpayee declared: "We are being threatened [by Pakistan] with a nuclear attack. Do they understand what it means? If they think we would wait for them to drop a bomb and face destruction, they are mistaken."[40] Although Vajpayee's government would subsequently affirm India's NFU policy in its 2003 official nuclear doctrine, his national security team had already presided over the creation and public release of a "draft" nuclear doctrine in 1999, which declared that "India will not be the first to initiate a nuclear strike." This declaration left open the possibility of using nuclear weapons first if India detected adversary preparations for nuclear attack.[41] Although the 1999 draft was described by the government as illustrative rather than authoritative, Vajpayee's statement above only a year later suggests that at least some of India's leaders had, from the beginning, been uncomfortable

34. Shivshankar Menon, "Speech by NSA Shri Shivshankar Menon at NDC on 'The Role of Force in Strategic Affairs'" (New Delhi: Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India, October 21, 2010), https://www.mea.gov.in/Speeches-Statements.htm?dtl/798/Speech+by+NSA+Shri+Shivshankar+Menon+at+NDC+on+The+Role+of+Force+in+Strategic+Affairs.
35. Vipin Narang, "Did India Change its Nuclear Doctrine? Much Ado about Nothing," IDSA Comment (New Delhi: Institute for Defence Studies and Analysis, March 1, 2011), https://idsa.in/idsacomments/DidIndiaChangeitsNuclearDoctrine_vnarang_010311.
36. Dhruva Jaishankar (@d_jaishankar), Twitter, July 1, 2016, 3:07 p.m., https://twitter.com/d_jaishankar/status/748941060727005184.
37. Ibid., 3:13pm, https://twitter.com/d_jaishankar/status/748942581074198528.
38. Ibid., 3:15pm, https://twitter.com/d_jaishankar/status/748943209510924289.
39. Kumar Sundaram and M.V. Ramana, "India and the Policy of No First Use of Nuclear Weapons," *Journal for Peace and Nuclear Disarmament*, Vol. 1, No. 1 (February 2018), pp. 152–168 doi.org/10.1080/25751654.2018.1438737.
40. Quoted in Sarabjit Pandher, "Talks Only on Return of PoK, Says Vajpayee," *Hindu*, February 7, 2000, https://www.thehindu.com/2000/02/07/stories/01070001.htm.
41. National Security Advisory Board, "India's Draft Nuclear Doctrine" (Washington, D.C.: Arms Control Association, August 17, 1999), https://www.armscontrol.org/act/1999_07-08/ffja99.

with an absolute NFU policy. His statement led to little public debate, and there was no attempt to reconcile it with India's reaffirmed NFU commitment in 2003. With his 2016 book, Menon became the most authoritative figure to argue that preemption may be consistent with India's official 2003 NFU declaration since its formal adoption.

Unlike Menon, who construed preemption as consistent with India's declared doctrine, other Indian officials have discussed explicitly revising or jettisoning NFU altogether. In 2012, for example, a group of retired Indian national security officials engaged in a public effort to convince the Indian government to explicitly permit India to use nuclear weapons in the event of an imminent nuclear attack—by definition, preemption. P.R. Chari, a former senior Indian defense official, chaired a nongovernmental task force that included a former Indian strategic forces commander (the senior-most military official in the Indian system responsible for nuclear weapons), which argued that NFU should mean that India would not "initiate" nuclear use. The task force stressed that "initiation" included "the process leading up to the actual use of a nuclear weapon by an adversary. This would include mating component systems and deploying warheads with the intent of using them."[42] In making the argument for preemption, Chari and colleagues were reverting to language from the 1999 "draft" doctrine that merely proscribed no first "initiation" of nuclear use.

A growing number of India's highest-serving defense officials have similarly argued for formally revising NFU.[43] Menon's thinking above on a "gray area" in NFU dovetails with writings by Lt. Gen. B.S. Nagal (ret.), a former strategic forces commander who subsequently served as an adviser on nuclear issues in the prime minister's office during Menon's tenure as national security adviser. Nagal advocated that India should explicitly abandon NFU in favor of a doctrine of "ambiguity," which encompasses potential first uses in preemption scenarios, launch on warning, or launch on launch (which requires detailed real-time surveillance and intelligence that India presumably currently lacks).[44] Nagal goes further than Menon and questions the morality of NFU, particularly in a democratic state such as India—asking how the Indian leader-

42. IPCS Task Force on India's Nuclear Doctrine, *India's Nuclear Doctrine: An Alternative Blueprint* (New Delhi: Institute of Peace and Conflict Studies, 2012).
43. Recently, career Indian intelligence official and former Deputy National Security Adviser S.D. Pradhan also expressed doubts about no first use. Pradhan, "Growing Chinese Nuclear Arsenal: Is China Changing Its Doctrine?" *Times of India*, July 31, 2018, https://blogs.timesofindia.indiatimes.com/ChanakyaCode/growing-chinese-nuclear-arsenal-is-china-changing-its-doctrine/.
44. Lt. Gen. B.S. Nagal, "Checks and Balances," *Force*, June 2014.

ship could accept significant casualties if it knew that Pakistan was making preparations for the imminent use of nuclear weapons.

Then, in November 2016, after Nagal's writings had caused a stir in India's strategic community and following the release of Menon's memoirs, Defense Minister Manohar Parrikar stated in his "personal capacity" that India should not declare whether or not it has a no-first-use policy. At a public book event, Parrikar used the opportunity of a question unrelated to Indian nuclear doctrine to offer his opinion on NFU, declaring: "A lot of people say India has a no-first-use nuclear policy, but why should I bind myself? I should say I'm a responsible nuclear power, and I will not use it irresponsibly."[45] He went on to refer to the "written strategy" in the doctrine as only a "guideline," and suggested that unpredictability had to be part of any strategy.[46] This public questioning of the sanctity of the NFU declaration by a sitting defense minister—without a formal rebuke from the government—is, to date, the most high-profile example of the erosion of India's NFU policy.

In sum, unlike his colleagues who have called for explicit revision to India's nuclear doctrine, Menon has interpreted preemption as consistent with India's current NFU declaration, obviating the need for any adjustment to the declaratory doctrine or policy—since publicly rolling back NFU would likely be more costly than creative reinterpretation. The question then becomes: What standard of evidence of enemy preparation would be required for the strictures of NFU to dissolve? Would Indian leaders presume imminent use in the face of verbal threats and clear evidence of tactical nuclear weapons batteries moving into the theater of battle? Menon's writings suggest that India's nuclear strategy may already include an exception for Indian first use in an easily imagined crisis scenario.

The puzzle for analysts of India's nuclear strategy has always been: Why inject ambiguity into India's NFU commitment, and specifically narrowly for preemptive use options? With its survivable nuclear force and a purported countervalue targeting strategy, India could absorb a Pakistani first use of nuclear weapons and still have sufficient forces to inflict unacceptable damage on high-value Pakistani targets. There is one potential logical reason to qualify NFU: if India does not have a countervalue targeting strategy, but rather is

45. "India Should Not Bind Itself to a 'No First Use Nuclear Policy,' says Manohar Parrikar," *Scroll*, November 10, 2016, https://scroll.in/latest/821251/india-should-not-bind-itself-to-a-no-first-use-nuclear-policy-says-manohar-parrikar. The use of the phrase "a lot of people say India has a no-first-use nuclear policy" is particularly notable. It is not the same as saying, "India has a no-first-use nuclear policy . . ."
46. Ibid.

considering counterforce options, where it cannot be as relaxed about accepting first use and the potential attrition of forces that would be required to destroy Pakistan's own nuclear forces. Any consideration of counterforce options must leave open the possibility of preemptive nuclear use.

Does private interest in counterforce options explain the seemingly persistent effort to carve out an exception to NFU for specifically preemptive use?[47] Menon suggests an answer in his book. First, he uses the past tense when discussing countervalue targeting, which many observers believe is India's targeting strategy. He writes, "Instead, the logical posture at first was countervalue targeting, or targeting an opponent's assets, rather than counterforce targeting, which concentrates on the enemy's military and command structures."[48] Is Menon implying that India has shifted away from countervalue to counterforce targeting? Although it is unclear here, his subsequent analysis reveals his explicit thinking about developing and shifting to a counterforce targeting strategy—if not now, maybe in the future—with the intention of fully disarming Pakistan of at least its strategic nuclear forces. Menon writes:

> What would be credible would be the message India conveyed by how it configures its forces. If Pakistan were to use tactical nuclear weapons against India, even against Indian forces in Pakistan, it would effectively be opening the door to a massive Indian first strike, having crossed India's declared red lines. There would be little incentive, once Pakistan had taken hostilities to the nuclear level, for India to limit its response, since that would only invite further escalation by Pakistan. India would hardly risk giving Pakistan the chance to carry out a massive nuclear strike after the Indian response to Pakistan using tactical nuclear weapons. In other words, Pakistani tactical nuclear weapons use would effectively free India to undertake a comprehensive first strike against Pakistan.[49]

Significantly, Menon includes the phrase "comprehensive first strike," evoking the Herman Kahn notion of a "splendid first strike."[50] Kahn's term of art is one with which Menon would be eminently familiar, and it means strategic nuclear counterforce.[51] Despite calls from India's strategic analysts to expunge "massive" retaliation from the doctrine given its perceived credibility prob-

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47. It is also possible that growing discomfort with an absolute NFU policy first led to consideration of preemptive nuclear use, which then led to consideration of counterforce options; the end result is the same, however.
48. Menon, *Choices*, p. 108.
49. Ibid., p. 117.
50. Herman Kahn, *On Thermonuclear War* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1961), pp. 36–37.
51. Elsewhere, Vice Adm. Verghese Koithara (ret.) advocates using the phrase "first strike" for circumstances in which an attack seeks "to eliminate or reduce the adversary's capability to carry out

lems, Menon instead reinterprets it to mean comprehensive counterforce rather than countervalue targeting. Recall, India's official nuclear doctrine does not prescribe countervalue targeting. A comprehensive first strike—counterforce—would by necessity be massive. And if one interprets preemption as something other than first use, then it would conceivably be consistent with India's existing nuclear doctrine.

Who would go first in a counterforce scenario is necessarily ambiguous. In Menon's example, India executes the counterforce strike following Pakistan's use of battlefield nuclear weapons. India may accept Pakistani first use if it were just on the battlefield, but as Vajpayee stated and Menon implies, Pakistan may be gravely mistaken if it believes that India will wait to allow it to destroy Indian cities or India's own nuclear forces. If, however, Pakistan anticipated such a disarming attempt after using battlefield nuclear weapons and is seized by use-them-or-lose-them fears, it would have an incentive to launch all of its nuclear weapons first, and would not restrict its first use just to the battlefield. For this reason, Menon recognizes that India may have no choice but to go first in such a scenario, to at least preemptively attack Pakistan's long-range nuclear systems. Indian counterforce options must thus retain the flexibility to be fully executed preemptively, imminently before Pakistan has even used nuclear weapons on the battlefield—precisely the gray area that Menon discusses. Indeed, nuclear counterforce options—those envisioned in extreme circumstances rather than a bolt-out-of-the-blue attack—must inherently have some elements of preemption baked in, in order to maximize the chance of success. As much as India might prefer a second-strike counterforce option, Pakistan's reaction to that possibility forces India to consider going first and preemptively itself.

Again, Menon is not alone in discussing or suggesting counterforce options. As Lieutenant General Nagal (ret.) wrote in 2015:

> Once the adversary has decided to initiate nuclear attacks on India or Indian forces anywhere, the aim [of India] will be to terminate the war at the earliest. One method will be to destroy the command and control system of the adversary to prevent further orders for nuclear strikes. This is feasible if all possible steps are taken to destroy the enemy's C4ISR [command, control, communication, computer, intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance] system and leadership. Selective targeting or small-scale strikes will not suffice and the call would be for massive retaliation to cause unacceptable damage in the expectation that these would be successful in eliminating the flow of orders.[52]

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nuclear strikes," while reserving the phrase "first use" for countervalue or counter-military targeting. Koithara, *Managing India's Nuclear Forces*, p. 77.

52. Nagal, "India's Nuclear Strategy to Deter," p. 14.

Nagal's ambiguous wording—"once the adversary has decided to initiate nuclear attacks"—leaves open the possibility of Indian preemption with a massive disarming "retaliatory" strike, and is especially noteworthy given the language of the 1999 draft nuclear doctrine and the Chari et al. task force, which argued that a decision to initiate a nuclear attack, rather than an actual nuclear detonation, should be the trigger for Indian nuclear use. Elsewhere, Nagal has written explicitly about preemptive counterforce: "A shift to a proactive policy is reassuring to the public. It does not allow destruction of the nation and strategic forces at the outset; hence the arsenal is intact for use. It provides a better range of options to launch decapitating and/or disarming strikes to deal with the adversary leadership/arsenal."[53] Then, in 2019, Nagal, writing in a volume published by the Indian Army's think tank, offered the most explicit argument for preemptive counterforce to date: "Strategic deterrence can follow a policy of first use when there is an unstable and unpredictable adversary, thereby eliminating the dilemma of responding to battlefield weapons or having to qualify circumstances of use with no first use…The basic requirement is to have an assured capability of intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance to detect, identify, track, and destroy the nuclear assets of the adversary. This capability must be real time, day and night, all-weather and multi-mode to make it fool proof…[which] allows the employment of nuclear weapons at the right time and place."[54] He goes on to identify a variety of command and control and military targets of interest to neutralize the Pakistani nuclear force, but specifically highlights the need to be able to destroy "nuclear forces underground or deployed in field areas."[55]

Like Menon, Nagal, the highest-level officer in India's nuclear system to write on these issues, explicitly advocates Indian preemptive nuclear use in a counterforce mode to try to disarm the adversary. Interestingly, he discusses not only hard counterforce targets—the nuclear systems that India could locate and destroy—but command and control nodes as well, including leadership decapitation, to render Pakistan's remaining nuclear force impotent. These latter targets would only amplify Pakistan's incentive to use all of its nuclear weapons first, while it retained the ability to do so, and not restrict its nuclear use to just the battlefield.

If India is indeed contemplating counterforce strategies, it would likely have to employ nuclear weapons rather than conventional weapons for two rea-

53. Nagal, "Checks and Balances," p. 14.
54. Lt. Gen. B.S. Nagal (ret.), "India's Nuclear Doctrine and Strategy," in Lt. Gen. A.K. Singh and Nagal, eds., *Military Strategy for India in the 21st Century* (New Delhi: Centre for Land Warfare Studies, 2019), p. 218.
55. Ibid., p. 222.

sons. First, the sheer number of conventional weapons required to destroy an adversary's nuclear weapons makes them more expensive than using nuclear weapons. Second, the limitations of India's ISR capabilities mean that India would need a nuclear blast radius to offset intelligence uncertainties in order to destroy Pakistani systems. Indeed, Nagal argues that a massive nuclear strike would be required to ensure that India could limit damage from Pakistan's nuclear systems.[56]

Such interest in preemptive counterforce would constitute a radical shift from India's initial post-1998 strategy designed to "ride out and survive a first attack and retaliate later" and its explicit rejection of launch-on-warning postures.[57] The logic of developing a counterforce option is to eliminate the specter of Pakistani strategic nuclear use altogether and free India to execute the massive conventional retaliation for which its formidable strike corps have been built. In theory, this could then deter Pakistan from sponsoring terrorist attacks on India's homeland by negating Pakistan's nuclear parity and exposing it to unrelenting Indian conventional and nuclear superiority.

Analysts can dismiss these musings as nothing more than the personal opinions of former officials. All of these statements generated substantial publicity in India and abroad, however, and offered opportunities for these officials and the government to deny interpretations of a shift in thinking.[58] They have refused to do so. Indeed, Menon would later declare that India's "nuclear doctrine has far greater flexibility than it gets credit for," implying that it is broad enough to encompass both massive countervalue retaliation and preemptive counterforce options.[59]

The next section examines India's investment in a diverse array of capabilities that would be useful for damage-limiting first strikes, but which otherwise make little sense for an assured retaliation or a minimum deterrence posture. Such investments are consistent with the strategic logic that Menon and other

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56. Vice Adm. Vijay Shankar (ret.), another former Strategic Forces commander, also concludes that India's strategic circumstances could require damage-limiting strikes, but argues that conventional counterforce weapons are sufficient. See Shankar, "Strategic Non-Nuclear Weapons: An Essential Consort to a Doctrine of No First Use" (New Delhi: Institute of Peace and Conflict Studies, January 13, 2014), http://www.ipcs.org/comm_select.php?articleNo=4256.
57. Rajesh Rajagopolan, "India: The Logic of Assured Retaliation," in Muthiah Alagappa, ed., *The Long Shadow: Nuclear Weapons and Security in 21st Century Asia* (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 2008), p. 199; and C. Raja Mohan, "Interview with Jaswant Singh, Minister of External Affairs," *Hindu*, November 29, 1999.
58. Max Fisher, "India, Long at Odds with Pakistan, May Be Rethinking Nuclear First Strikes," *New York Times*, March 31, 2017, https://www.nytimes.com/2017/03/31/world/asia/india-long-at-odds-with-pakistan-may-be-rethinking-nuclear-first-strikes.html.
59. Ibid.